

Diesel export controls likely if prices remain elevated

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Diesel export controls likely if prices remain elevated past mid-October. The White House is likely to impose export controls on diesel and other refined products (65% odds) if diesel prices remain elevated past their 2022 high of \$5.82 per gallon past 15 October, as political pressure to take action regarding high diesel prices is growing.

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Recent comments from Republican Senate candidates in Iowa and Michigan, and from Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-SD) last week, reflect the mounting tide of support in the party for some action on diesel prices, which are particularly salient in Republican-leaning, agriculture-heavy states. Republicans are tied against or outright trailing Democratic opponents in Republican-leaning states like Iowa and Texas and national Republicans have come to see action on diesel as a necessity if they want to retain control of the Senate.

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If imposed, export controls would likely take the form of a quota-style approach that aims to cap total US exports at pre-war levels of around 1-1.2 million of barrels per day. Enforcement, however, would be challenging. Price impact would be both limited and temporary, and would likely be limited to interior and Gulf Coast states; prices on the coasts would likely spike, in tandem with global prices.

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Any arresting of the upward curve in prices would push back the point at which pressure on the administration to act become overwhelming. The reopening of the Exxon Mobil refinery in Joliet, Illinois will probably bring down Midwest gasoline and diesel prices, potentially buying the administration some time.

Iowa looks like a toss-up race after Marist poll. Democrat Josh Turek led Republican Rep. Ashley Hinson (R-IA) by a massive eight points in a Marist poll of the Iowa Senate race out today, Turek's best poll of

the cycle by far.

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The poll will put Turek slightly ahead of Hinson in polling averages, mostly because his eight-point lead is far greater than the small leads that both candidates have exchanged in recent polling.

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Marist is high-quality pollster with an A- grade from Silver Bulletin based on its past performance, so it's worth taking this poll seriously as an indication of the direction of the race. There is reason to think, though, that the eight-point lead—which is an outlier compared to recent polling—is an overstatement; Marist did not weight its sample by partisanship, which is now a standard step by pollsters to correct for partisan differences in response rates.

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Regardless of methodological decisions, this poll is bad news for Republicans in Iowa, potentially reflecting anger among rural voters over high diesel prices. Iowa now looks like little better than a toss-up, a meaningful gain for Democrats; it would probably take a significant drop in gas and diesel prices to shift the race back toward Republicans.

White House's NIH grant plan will face congressional, judicial pushback. The White House is reportedly moving ahead with a plan to establish a new board of political appointees that would have the final say over whether to approve grants from the National Institutes of Health, a process that has traditionally been at arm's length from political influence.

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This move appears partially intended to give the White House a lever to cut grant funding to Harvard University, which has become a priority for Trump and Office of Management and Budget director Russ Vought. It's part of a larger effort to bring grantmaking—typically the purview of largely career staff at agencies—into closer alignment with the administration's political priorities.

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The plan will face major pushback from Congress, which passed a funding patch earlier this month that included language that blocked OMB from finalizing a rule giving political appointees review powers over agency funding decisions; Democrats and some Republicans could seek to include similar language in another funding bill in the post-midterm lame duck session.

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The courts would likely be another major hurdle for the administration, whose previous attempts to block funding to universities—and Harvard in particular—were largely stymied by judges. How the courts handle likely suits over a new executive order will depend on the details, but given the complex procedural issues involved and courts' inclinations over the last eighteen months, this would likely be an uphill battle for the administration.

Quote of the Day

"I gave absolutely no credence, and will not give credence to the election, when it comes to Iran. It doesn't even enter my mind." - President Donald Trump addressing the UN General Assembly this morning. We do not expect any talks around UNGA to lead to progress in US-Iran negotiations, and are holding to our 60% odds for a continued standoff into 2027.

On the Radar

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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